

Session 6: A Man in the Field

Key Takeaways

- The narrative hinges on Yoseph's encounter with the man in the field. If Yoseph had not met this man, he and his entire family would have died in the famine.
- For the biblical authors, every moment of human existence is woven into God's plan for creation.
- The Midianites and Ishmaelites become entangled in the brothers' plot to get rid of Yoseph. It's as if all of Abraham's non-chosen children conspire to oppose the chosen son.

Overview of Genesis 37:15-30

A – Genesis 37:15-17

- Yoseph goes to seek brothers, cannot find, meets a man in the field
- **Where** are the brothers?

B – Genesis 37:18-25a

- Brothers see Yoseph coming
- **Reuven** intercedes to save Yoseph: "Don't spill blood ... or let our hand be against him."
- Yoseph thrown down into pit

B' – Genesis 37:25b-28

- Brothers see traders coming
- **Yehudah** intercedes to spare Yoseph: "What's the gain of murder? ... Don't let our hand be against him."
- Yoseph taken up from pit, taken down to Egypt

A' – 37:29-30

- Reuven seeks brother, cannot find
- " **Where** will I go?"

Genesis 37:15-30. Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).

This central paragraph of chapter 37 is designed as a three-part symmetry, with matching outer panels (37:15-17 and 37:29-30) and matching inner panels (37:18-25a and 37:25b-28). The matching parts create

important comparisons and contrasts that will be further developed in the following narratives.

15 And a man **found** him,
and look, he was wandering about in a field,

and the man asked, saying ,
“What are you looking for?”

16 And he said,
“I am looking for **my brothers**.
Tell me, please,
where are they shepherding?”

17 **And the man said** ,
“They journeyed on from here.
Indeed, I heard them saying,
‘Let’s go to Dothan.’”

And Yoseph **went** after **his brothers**,
and he **found** them in **Dothan** .

18 And they saw him from afar,
and before he came near to them,
they made a deceitful plan to kill him.

19 And they said, each to **his brother**,
“Look, **this master** of **the dreams**, he comes!

20 And now, come, **let’s murder him**,
and let’s **throw him into one of the pits**,
and we will say,

‘A terrible **animal ate him!**’
and we will see what comes of **his dreams!**”

21 And **Reuven** heard,
and he delivered him from their hand,

and he said ,
“**Don’t strike his life!**”

22 And **Reuven** said to them,
“**Don’t spill blood!**

Throw him into this pit that's in the wilderness.

But don't send out a hand against him."

It was in order to deliver him from their hand,
to return him to his father.

23 And it came about when Yoseph came to his brothers,
that they stripped Yoseph of his robe,
the robe of many colors that was on him,

24 and they took him and they threw him into the pit,
and the pit was empty, with no water in it.

25a And they sat down to eat bread.

25b And they lifted their eyes and they saw,
and look, a caravan of Yishma'elites coming from Gil'ad,
and their camels were carrying spice-gum, balm, and myrrh,
they were coming to go down to Egypt .

26 And Yehudah said to his brothers,
"What profit is there if we murder our brother,
and cover up his blood?

27 Come , and let's sell him to the Yishma'elites ,
and don't let our hand be upon him ,
because, he is our brother and our flesh ."

And his brothers listened.

a 28 And Midianite men, traders, passed by,

b and they drew up and brought Yoseph up from the pit,

b' and they sold Yoseph to the Yishma'elites for twenty silver pieces,

a' and they brought Yoseph to Egypt .

29 And Reuven returned to the pit,
and look, Yoseph was not (יֵאֵ) in the pit,

and he tore his clothes.

30 **And he returned to his brothers,**
and he said,
“The child, he is **no more (אֵינוֹ)** !
And as for me, **where am I to go?!**”

Genesis 37:15-30. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).

The Mysterious Man in the Field

This scene of Yoseph encountering a random man in the field is not random at all, but a key part of the narrative message at work in the larger story of Yoseph. If it were not for this man, Yoseph would not have found his brothers, and he would not have been kidnapped, sold as a slave, and taken to Egypt. Without going to Egypt, Yoseph would not have been discovered by Pharaoh and elevated as ruler of Egypt able to save his family from the famine.

If Yoseph had not met this man, he and his entire family would have died in the famine.

It cannot be a coincidence, then, that Yoseph encounters a “man” (אִישׁ) who directs him toward his brothers’ true location. We are meant to see a similarity here with Abraham’s encounter with the “men” (אֲנָשִׁים) who walk by his tent (Gen. 18:1-5), and with the “man” (אִישׁ) who comes to Yaaqov at the Yabbok and picks a fight with him (Gen. 32:23-32). We are surely meant to see this man as yet another disguised divine messenger (that is what the men Abraham encountered are called in Gen. 19:1-3) who guides Yoseph toward his destiny. God intentionally leads the beloved Yoseph into danger as part of his paradoxical plan to exalt him.

The “Man” in Genesis 37:15-17

Gen. 37:15 And **a man (אִישׁ)** found him, and behold **he was wandering (תעה)** in the field, and **the man (אִישׁ)** **asked him (שאל)**, saying, “**What (מה)** do you seek?”

The “Men” in Genesis 18, 21 and 32

Gen. 18:2 And Avraham lifted his eyes, and behold, **three men (אִישׁ)** standing over him

Gen. 21:14 ... and [Hagar] went and **wandered (תעה)** in the wilderness

Gen. 21:17 ... and the angel of God called to Hagar from heaven and said to her, “**What (מה)** to you, Hagar?”

Gen. 32:24 And Yaaqov was left alone, and **a man (אִישׁ)** struggled with him

Men in Genesis 18-37. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).

The “Man” in Genesis 37:15-17

The “Men” in Genesis 18, 21 and 32

Gen. 32:28 And [the man] said, “ **What (מה)** is your name?”

Gen. 32:30-31 And Ya'akov **asked (שאל)** and said, “Tell me your name?” And he said, “For **what (למה)** do you **ask (שאל)** for my name?”

Men in Genesis 18-37. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).

Yoseph is likely alluding to this very scene when he speaks with his brothers in Egypt.

Genesis 45:7-8 Instructor's Translation

⁷ Elohim sent me before you,
to preserve for you a remnant in the earth,
and to keep you alive by a great deliverance.

⁸Now, therefore, it was not you all who sent me here, but Elohim;
and he has made me a father to Pharaoh
and lord of all his household
and ruler over all the land of Egypt.

Murderous Brothers and Rescue Plans

The jealous anger of Yoseph’s brothers recalls a motif that has repeated in every generation of characters. When God elevates his chosen one, the non-chosen people consistently respond with anger and jealousy that leads to violent conflict and deception. Less often, the non-chosen people respond with humility and a recognition of God’s blessing.

The Chosen	The Non-Chosen’s Negative Response	
Humanity	Land animals, including the snake	Genesis 1, 3
Abel	Cain: anger and violence	Genesis 4
Noah	Generation of the flood: violence in the land	Genesis 6
Abraham	Lot: conflict over land possession	Genesis 13

The Chosen and Non-Chosen’s Responses. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).

The Chosen	The Non-Chosen's Negative Response	
Isaac & Sarah	Ishmael & Hagar: Sarah is jealous and abusive	Genesis 16, 21
Isaac	Abimelech: jealous and angry	Genesis 26
Jacob	Esau: Jacob is deceptive, Esau is violently angry	Genesis 25, 27
<i>The Chosen and Non-Chosen's Responses. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).</i>		

These narratives paint an accumulative portrait of a humanity that does not understand, or feels threatened by, God's purpose to raise up one human family among the many to be the vehicle of divine rule and blessing for all the others.

This is precisely what the brothers resist: the elevation of their youngest brother to the place of rule over the family.

Reuven and Yehudah as Rivals

Notice how the literary design of this paragraph contrasts the unsuccessful plan of Reuven, the firstborn of Leah, with the successful plan of Yehudah, the fourth-born of Leah. This is a key part of the design of the larger Yoseph story to elevate Yehudah as the real leader among the brothers. This scene is matched by the later scene when Reuven and Yehudah propose plans to Yaaqov for returning to Egypt to get more food (in [Gen. 43](#)), and Yehudah's plan succeeds.

Genesis 37	Genesis 43	Genesis 49
Reuven's plan to rescue Yoseph fails	Reuven's plan to offer his sons fails	Reuven is cursed for his selfishness
Yehudah's plan to sell Yoseph succeeds	Yehudah's plan to offer himself succeeds	Yehudah appointed as the royal leader of his brothers
Yoseph sold into slavery	Yoseph becomes ruler of Egypt	Yoseph is blessed more than his brothers
<i>Genesis 37 Leading to Genesis 49. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).</i>		

The Sons of Abraham Conspire Against the Chosen Son

The narrative clearly highlights how all the brothers are in the plot to resist Yaaqov's elevation of Yoseph and to prevent his dreams from coming true.

But there are other, more distant relative brothers who also become entangled in the plot. The presence of the Yishmaelites widens the circle of culpability, so that the entire family of Abraham plays a role in the loss of the beloved son.

Genesis 37:25b Instructor's Translation

And behold, a caravan of **Yishmaelites** (ישמעאלים) came from Gilead

Genesis 37:28 Instructor's Translation

And **Midianite** (מדינים) men, traders, passed by, and [the brothers] drew up and raised up Yoseph out of the pit, and they sold (מכר) Yoseph to the **Yishmaelites** (ישמעאלים) ... and they brought Yoseph there.

Genesis 37:36 Instructor's Translation

And the **Medanim** (מדנים) sold him to Egypt, to Potiphar the captain of the guard ...

Genesis 39:1 Instructor's Translation

And Potiphar ... an Egyptian man purchased him from the hand of the **Yishmaelites** (ישמעאלים) who took him down to Egypt.

The narrative clearly leads the reader to associate all of these titles as references to a single group of caravan traders. However, each of these three titles in Genesis 37 is linked with the wider family of Abraham listed in Genesis 25.

Genesis 25:1-6 Instructor's Translation

¹ Now Avraham took **another wife**, whose name was **Keturah**.

² **She bore to him** Zimran and Jokshan and **Medan** and **Midian** and Ishbak and Shuah. ...

⁵ Now Avraham gave all that he had to Yitzhak; ⁶ but to the sons of his concubines, Avraham gave gifts while he was still living, and sent them away from his son Yitzhak eastward, to the land of the east.

Genesis 25:12-13, 18 Instructor's Translation

¹² Now these are the generations of Yishmael, Avraham's son, whom **Hagar** the Egyptian, **Sarah's slave**, **bore to Avraham**;

¹³ and these are the names of the sons of **Yishmael**, by their names, in the order of their birth: Nebaioth, the firstborn of Yishmael, and Kedar and Adbeel and Mibsam ...

¹⁸ They settled from Havilah to Shur which is east of Egypt as one goes toward Assyria; he settled in defiance of all his relatives.

These different tribes descending from Abraham have distinct origins. Medan and Midian come from Keturah, while Yishmael comes from Hagar. However, the title Yishmaelites in Genesis 37:25 is used to refer to a

broader category of tribal merchants from the east, which can include various sub-clans as Medan and Midian.

This same association of these tribes appears in Judges 8:22-24 and in Isaiah 60:5b-7.

Judges 8:12, 21-24

¹² When Zebah and Zalmunna fled, he pursued them and captured the two kings of **Midian**, Zebah and Zalmunna, and routed the whole army. ...

^{21b} So Gideon arose and killed Zebah and Zalmunna, and took the crescent ornaments which were on their camels' necks. ²² Then the men of Israel said to Gideon, "Rule over us, both you and your son, also your son's son, for you have delivered us from the hand of **Midian**."

²³ But Gideon said to them, "I will not rule over you, nor shall my son rule over you; the LORD shall rule over you." ²⁴ Yet Gideon said to them, "I would request of you, that each of you give me an earring from his spoil." (For they had gold earrings, because they were **Yishmaelites**.)

Isaiah 60:5b-7

^{5b} The wealth of the nations will come to you.

⁶ A multitude of camels will cover you, the young camels of **Midian** and **Ephah**; all those from **Sheba** will come.

They will bring gold and frankincense, and will bear good news of the praises of the LORD.

⁷ All the flocks of **Kedar** will be gathered together to you, the rams of **Nebaioth** will minister to you; they will go up with acceptance on my altar, and I shall glorify my glorious house.

Genesis 25:2-4 – Sons of Keturah

² Keturah bore to [Avraham] Zimran and Jokshan and **Medan** and **Midian** and Ishbak and Shuah. ³ Jokshan became the father of **Sheba** and Dedan. ... ⁴ The sons of Midian were **Ephah** and Epher

Genesis 25:13 – Sons of Yishmael

The names of the sons of **Yishmael**, by their names, in the order of their birth: **Nebaioth**, the firstborn of Yishmael, and **Kedar** and Adbeel and Mibsam

Judges and Isaiah in Genesis 25. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).

Conclusion

Genesis 37 portrays all the sons of Yaaqov as replaying their fathers' failures, an intensified act of betrayal against the beloved son of God's promise. The appearance of the Yishmaelites and Midianites includes the wider family of Abraham in the betrayal, so that the entire line of Abraham's blessed lineage is caught up (intentionally or unintentionally) in the betrayal that will fracture the family, only to bring it together in the ultimate reunification under Yoseph's reign.

Reflection Question

What can we take away from how the biblical authors incorporate Yoseph's encounter with a man in the field?